

PRINTABLE INTERACTIVE WORKBOOK

FAST MINDS

How to Thrive If You Have ADHD (Or Think You Might)

Craig Surman, M.D. & Tim Bilkey, M.D.

with Karen Weintraub

Expanded Duplex Edition • Dot-Grid Worksheets

START HERE

How This Workbook Is Organized

This printable workbook follows the twelve-chapter structure of *FAST MINDS*. It keeps full chapter exercises intact with generous dot-grid response areas for handwriting.

Worksheet Rhythm

Rhythm Stage	Purpose & Focus
ORIENT	Brief clinical context needed to understand the exercise and principles.
NOTICE	Recognition, self-inventory prompts, and awareness logs.
WORK WITH IT	The main writing, thought record, or planning exercise.
CARRY FORWARD	A short synthesis, practical reminder, or reusable takeaway.

Personal Notes & Intentions

Use this space to outline your main goals for working through this book:

PART I

Understanding FAST MINDS

Notice your traits, identify what matters, study when you function well, and work with the emotional load around difficult moments.

ORIENT

Chapter 1: What Are FAST MINDS?

Notice which FAST MINDS traits affect your day-to-day life. Check the traits that resonate and note how they show up.

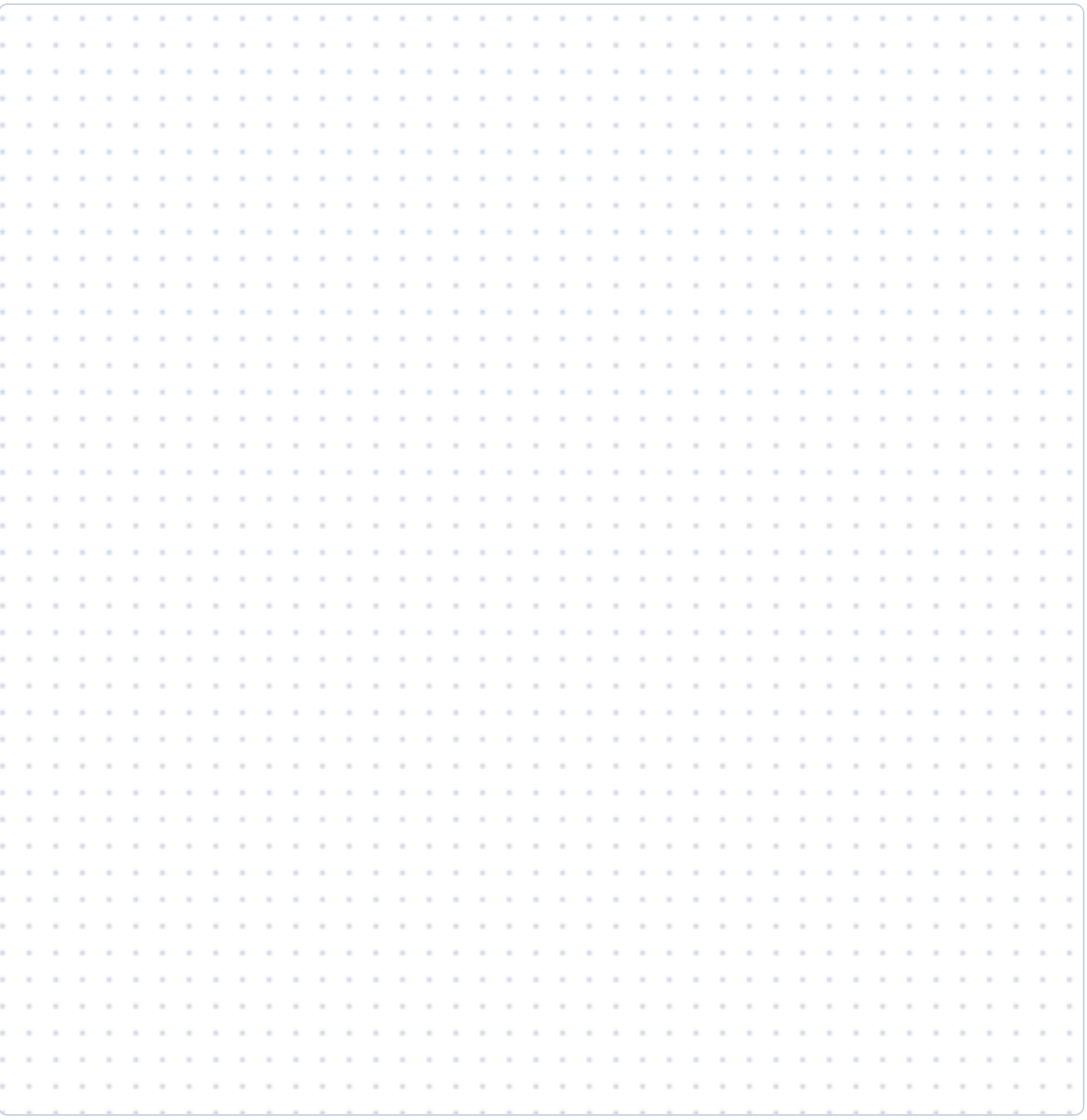
- ☐ **FORGETFUL:** Do you forget what people told you, where you put things, or daily appointments?
- ☐ **ACHIEVING BELOW POTENTIAL:** Do you feel you underachieve relative to your capabilities?
- ☐ **STUCK IN A RUT:** Do you feel trapped playing catch-up instead of moving ahead in key life areas?
- ☐ **TIME CHALLENGED:** Are you often late, underestimate task duration, or lose track of time?
- ☐ **MOTIVATIONALLY CHALLENGED:** Do you procrastinate, rely on deadline panic, or leave tasks half-done?
- ☐ **IMPULSIVE:** Do you act without anticipating consequences, blurt things out, or make rash choices?
- ☐ **NOVELTY SEEKING:** Are you easily bored, drawn toward excitement, or overcommit?
- ☐ **DISTRACTIBLE:** Do sights, sounds, thoughts, or low-priority activities pull you away?
- ☐ **SCATTERED:** Is it hard to keep physical spaces, schedules, papers, or projects organized?

Initial Trait Observations

NOTICE

What Stands Out?

Which traits create the most effort or disruption in your life? Which traits are present but manageable? Detail the specific patterns, triggers, and daily impacts below.



WORK WITH IT

Three Priorities

Think of three tasks or situations that you really wish could flow better, that disrupt your quality of life, or that you will be upset about in the coming months if left unresolved.

1. Priority Task or Situation

2. Priority Task or Situation

3. Priority Task or Situation

CARRY FORWARD

Key Points: What Are FAST MINDS?

A quick recap to keep this chapter oriented before you move on.

KEY POINTS

- Plenty of people recognize FAST MINDS traits in themselves without meeting the full bar for an ADHD diagnosis — the traits are still worth working with either way.
- No two people have the same mix of traits, so the strategies that help will be personal to you, not one-size-fits-all.

One Thing I Want to Remember From This Chapter

ORIENT

Chapter 2: Tune In to Your FAST MIND

THE FAST MINDS ACRONYM BREAKDOWN

F — Forgetful

A — Achieving below potential

S — Stuck in a rut

T — Time challenged

M — Motivationally challenged

I — Impulsive

N — Novelty seeking

D — Distractible

S — Scattered

Write a description of your unique version of FAST MINDS. Reference the 9 traits above: how do they show up in your life, which ones create the most friction, and what conditions help you operate at your best?

NOTICE

Focus on the Flow

Recall moments when you were fully engaged, focused, and effective without self-criticism. Describe three specific flow moments in detail below.

Flow Moment 1:

Flow Moment 2:

Flow Moment 3:

WORK WITH IT

Successful Events Analysis

Successful Event #1

Question	Details & Context
What was it?	
When & Where?	
Who was there?	
How did you make it happen?	

Successful Event #2

Question	Details & Context
What was it?	
When & Where?	
Who was there?	
How did you make it happen?	

CARRY FORWARD

Key Points: Tune In to Your FAST MIND

A quick recap to keep this chapter oriented before you move on.

KEY POINTS

- These traits show up because of how your brain operates — not because you're lazy or don't care.
- FAST MINDS looks different depending on context; naming your own pattern is the first step toward adapting to it.
- You engage more easily in some roles and settings than others — understanding what supports your "flow" helps you get more out of everyday life.

One Thing I Want to Remember From This Chapter

ORIENT

Chapter 3: Cognitive Thought Record

A thought record is a basic CBT tool for noticing unproductive patterns of thought around emotionally charged situations, and redirecting your effort toward a more constructive response.

STEP 1: NOTICE THE SITUATION(S)

jot down three recent situations where things didn't go your way and you felt upset — a few words each is enough:

1.

2.

3.

The One You'll Work Through Below

STEP 2: NOTICE THE THOUGHTS

What Was Going Through Your Head?

STUCK FOR WORDS? TRY FINISHING ONE OF THESE

- "I did that because ____."
- "That happened because I am ____."
- Or even just, "I ____."

STEP 3: SEPARATE CONTROL

What Could You Control?

STEP BACK AND ASK YOURSELF

- Could this have happened to anyone, not just you?
- Was any part of it genuinely out of your control?
- Is your FAST MIND one of the factors that made this harder to avoid?

STEP 4: CHOOSE A USEFUL RESPONSE

Useful Coaching Statement

Try a shape like: "Because I tend to make mistakes when __, I can work on avoiding that by __. When it happens anyway, the kind thing to tell myself is __."

CARRY FORWARD

Key Points: Cognitive Thought Record

A quick recap to keep this chapter oriented before you move on.

KEY POINTS

- Adult ADHD and FAST MINDS traits are brain-based — they are not a personal failing.
- Catching distorted, self-critical thinking early makes it far easier to swap in a more workable response.
- A short, kind phrase you can say to yourself in the moment goes a long way toward draining out the emotion of a setback.

One Thing I Want to Remember From This Chapter

PART II

A FAST MINDS Operating Manual

Use clear plans, reduce distraction, manage critical moments, practice pausing, build supportive habits, and care for your body.

ORIENT

Chapter 4: The Prefrontal Checklist

Before starting an important task, check your operating conditions:

- ☐ Is the next step vivid and clear in my mind?
- ☐ Am I internally distracted? (thoughts, stress, restlessness)
- ☐ Is my environment distracting? (sensory, virtual, clutter)

Making Tasks Matter (Expanded — Part 1)

Connect avoided tasks to larger roles, values, and motivators:

[illegible]

WORK WITH IT

Making Tasks Matter (Expanded — Part 2)

Continue identifying tasks that trigger resistance or delay. Reframe each responsibility by grounding it in personal values, long-term goals, or emotional importance.

[illegible]

WORK WITH IT

Planning System Setup (Part 1)

Establish a clear, reliable external architecture for your schedule, tasks, and daily logs so your mind stays free to focus.

Function	Where Will It Live?	How Will I Use It?
To-Do Lists		
Thought Capture		
Live Day Logs		

WORK WITH IT

Planning System Setup (Part 2)

Define dedicated tools and digital calendar environments to keep commitments visual and easy to manage.

Function / Tool	Where Will It Live?	How Will I Use It?
Hobonichi Planner		
Daily Diary		
Digital ical		

INTERNAL DISTRACTION

Capture Popcorn Thoughts

When random thoughts, sudden reminders, or unrelated impulses pop into your head while working, write them here immediately to clear your mind and return to focus.



WORK WITH IT

Choosing Steps You Can Work With

A big task usually feels impossible only because it hasn't been broken down yet. Pick one task you've been avoiding, then write out each concrete step in order — small enough that you could start the very next one today. If a step still feels too big, split it again until it does.

[illegible]

Managing a Messy Work Area

- ☐ Does every item in this space have a "home" it returns to?
- ☐ Is my workspace set up for the task I do most here?
- ☐ Have I cleared one surface I can start on tomorrow?
- ☐ Is there a single landing spot for incoming papers or mail?

ORIENT

Mindfulness for a FAST MIND

Mindfulness is the practice of noticing a thought or urge without immediately reacting to it — useful for a mind that jumps quickly from impulse to action.

A Moment You Paused and Noticed

Describe a moment today (or recently) when you noticed a thought, urge, or feeling without immediately acting on it. What did you notice?

How grounded did you feel in that moment (0 – 10)?

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	----

CARRY FORWARD

Key Points: The Prefrontal Checklist

A quick recap to keep this chapter oriented before you move on.

KEY POINTS

- A vivid next step and a low-distraction setting are the two biggest levers for staying engaged in a task.
- Before starting something important, check whether your plan is clear, whether you're internally distracted, and whether your environment is working against you.
- An external system for tasks, thoughts, and daily logs frees up mental effort for the work itself.

One Thing I Want to Remember From This Chapter

ORIENT

Chapter 5: Be Your Own Chief Executive

Identify where your internal executive system struggles, and pair each challenge with a practical "peripheral brain"—a tool, system, or cue that carries the cognitive load for you.

Executive Challenge vs. Peripheral Brain Support

[illegible]

DESIGN A SYSTEM

Critical Moment System Design

Outline your triggers, the protective tool/person you'll activate, and your environment setup:

1. Critical Trigger Moment / Fork in the Road

2. Protective Tool, Peripheral Brain, or Support Person

3. Environment Setup & Friction Removal

4. Personal Action Plan & Reminder Cue

NOTICE

Getting a Handle on Critical Moments

A critical moment is a fork in the road — the point where you either follow an old pattern or choose a better one. Name a few of yours.

[illegible]

CHECKLIST

Checklist for Effective Executive Habits

An executive habit works when it's easy to repeat without thinking hard about it. Check the ones already true for you, and treat the unchecked ones as your next targets.

- ☐ I have a single place I capture every task and commitment.
- ☐ I check my calendar and task list at the same time every day.
- ☐ I set a reminder for anything more than a day out.
- ☐ I carry or keep nearby a "peripheral brain" tool I actually use.
- ☐ I have a designated spot for the things I need to leave the house with.
- ☐ I review my week ahead at a consistent time (e.g., Sunday evening).

What Would I Need to Change to Check All These Boxes?

NOTICE

Recognize the Impact — What Would Other People Say?

Think of someone close to you. What would they say about a time your impulsivity affected them, a decision, or a plan?

ANGLES WORTH CONSIDERING

- Do they think you act without thinking things through?
- Do they find you hard to predict or rely on?
- Do they feel cut off or unheard in conversation with you?
- Has an impulsive choice ever put you at real risk — physically, financially, or otherwise?

ORIENT

Chapter 6: Don't Just Do It—Think About It!

Identify impulsivity triggers: emotional decision making, nearsighted thinking, or novelty seeking. Use the pause button to widen the gap between impulse and action.

WORK WITH IT

Using the Pause Button

[illegible]

WORK WITH IT

Impulsivity Thought Record

THREE COMMON DRIVERS TO CHECK FOR

- Emotional decision making — acting on a feeling before it's passed.
- Nearsighted thinking — focusing on right now and losing sight of consequences later.
- Novelty seeking — chasing the exciting option over the sensible one.

[illegible]

Common thinking errors: all-or-nothing thinking, overgeneralizing, personalizing, catastrophizing.

CARRY FORWARD

Critical Impulsive Moments & Habits List

List the moments where impulsivity tends to take over, and the habit or pause-button response you want to build in its place.

BEFORE YOU FILL THIS IN, ASK YOURSELF

- Which critical moments of impulsivity can I see coming?
- Is novelty seeking, emotion, or a lack of foresight likely to get in the way?
- Which thinking errors am I most at risk of in that moment?
- What rational response could I rehearse ahead of time?
- What pausing habit could I practice to make a better choice?

[illegible]

WORK WITH IT

Reward Yourself Often

A FAST MIND sustains effort better with frequent, small rewards than with one big payoff far in the future. Daily rewards don't need to be expensive — a favorite playlist, a bubble bath, time with a pet. For the tasks you dread most, allow yourself a bigger reward, or consider outsourcing the task entirely. It helps to brainstorm a whole list of rewards at once, so you're not stuck inventing one in the moment — and to refresh the list once the old ones stop feeling special.

[illegible]

ORIENT

Chapter 7: Find Where and How You Thrive

Build habit systems supported by triggers, meaning, and environment rather than relying on pure willpower.

Habit + Reminder + Meaning Matrix

[illegible]

DESIGN YOUR ENVIRONMENT

Better Path + Supporting Structure

Instead of pushing uphill against friction, design a "Better Path"—an environment and workflow that naturally steers you toward your target behavior.

1. Current Frictional Path & Friction Points

2. Design of the "Better Path" (Structures, Cues, Friction Removal)

NOTICE

Finding the Right Environment for You

Habits stick best in environments built to support them. Where, physically and socially, do you do your best work?



CARRY FORWARD

Steps to Practicing Habits

Most habits form through repeated practice, backed by two allies: a peripheral brain (something outside yourself that carries the reminder) and accountability (someone or something that notices whether you followed through).

- ☐ Start smaller than feels necessary.
- ☐ Attach the new habit to a routine you already do.
- ☐ Track it somewhere visible for at least two weeks.
- ☐ Expect setbacks and restart without judgment.
- ☐ Adjust the habit's size or trigger if it keeps failing.
- ☐ Celebrate the streak, not just the end goal.

My Next Habit to Practice

CARRY FORWARD

Key Points: Find Where and How You Thrive

A quick recap to keep this chapter oriented before you move on.

KEY POINTS

- Building a new habit takes deliberate, repeated practice — and FAST MINDS traits can make that practice harder to sustain.
- Shape your environment so the better habit is also the easier one.
- Clear goals paired with quick, small rewards make new strategies much easier to stick with.
- Tracking progress, using reminders, and staying accountable to someone else all reinforce a habit while it's still new.

One Thing I Want to Remember From This Chapter

TRACK FOR 7 DAYS

Chapter 8: 24-Hour Cycle Review

SLEEP / WAKE CYCLE	D1	D2	D3	D4	D5	D6	D7
Wind down / relax before bed?							
Get 7-9 hours of sleep?							
Restful, dark sleep environment?							
Wake early enough to start on time?							
Avoid excess caffeine late in day?							
Avoid napping during the day?							
NUTRITION	D1	D2	D3	D4	D5	D6	D7
Eat a healthy breakfast?							
Have healthy food available?							
Eat small regular meals?							
Avoid fast / junk food?							
EXERCISE & RELAXATION	D1	D2	D3	D4	D5	D6	D7
Exercise at least 30 minutes?							
Clothes/equipment prepared?							
Take dedicated relaxation time?							

WORK WITH IT

Self-Care Action Plan

Based on your 7-day review, map out specific, achievable commitments to support your biological and psychological baseline.

Sleep & Rest Adjustments

Nutrition & Energy Routines

Exercise & Physical Activation

CARRY FORWARD

Key Points: 24-Hour Cycle Review

A quick recap to keep this chapter oriented before you move on.

KEY POINTS

- Regular sleep, food, and movement work as a kind of baseline medicine for a FAST MIND.
- Matching your effort to your natural energy rhythms gets you more focus with less strain.
- Spot the critical moments that tend to derail your day before they happen.
- Back any new habit with real structure — real accountability to track progress.

One Thing I Want to Remember From This Chapter

ORIENT

Chapter 9: Help Other People "Get It"

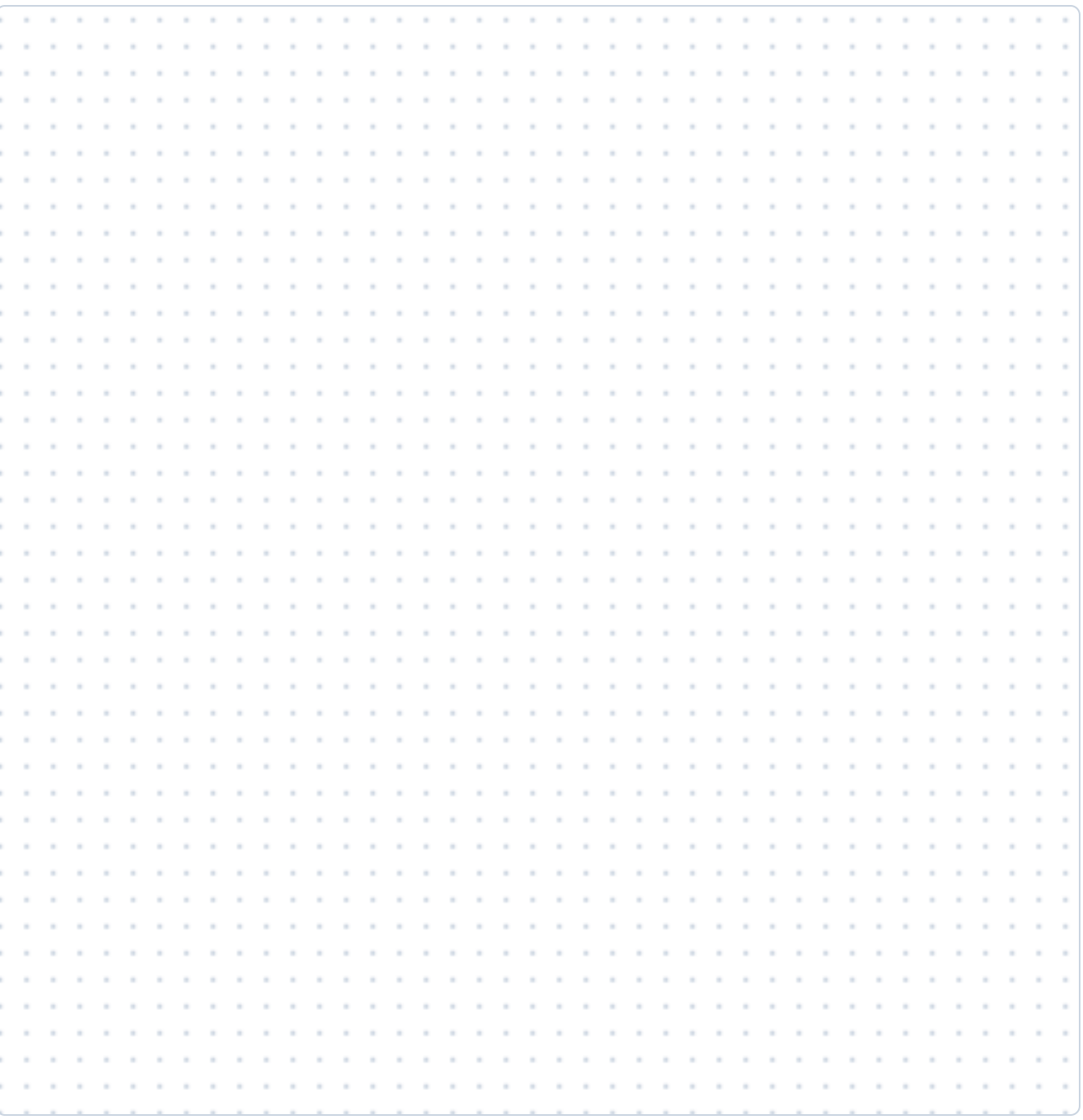
Communicate needs clearly, practice soundbites, and request specific accommodations rather than expecting others to infer what helps.

Challenging Tasks & Accommodations

CARRY FORWARD

My Communication Script & Requests

Draft precise script soundbites to share with family, colleagues, or managers. Focus on explaining how you work best and what support or boundaries yield optimal results.



NOTICE

Managing Emotional Communication

If you feel yourself getting rash, impulsive, or emotional mid-conversation, press your own pause button before you respond — a breath, a beat, or a short break can change how the rest of the exchange goes.

[illegible]

CARRY FORWARD

Being Effective Interpersonally

A few honest questions can reveal patterns worth working on: do you tend to assume you already know what someone's about to say? Do you monopolize the conversation, or drift out of it? Do meetings or commitments that matter to other people slip your mind? Use the checklist below as a running practice, not a one-time score.

- ☐ I acknowledge the other person's feelings before explaining mine.
- ☐ I use "I" statements instead of blame.
- ☐ I ask what the other person actually needs from me.
- ☐ I say what support or accommodation would help, specifically.
- ☐ I follow up afterward if I said I would.

A Relationship or Working Pattern I Want to Strengthen

Who is it, and which one or two items above would make the biggest difference there?

CARRY FORWARD

Key Points: Help Other People "Get It"

A quick recap to keep this chapter oriented before you move on.

KEY POINTS

- Keep the other person's side of the conversation in mind — aim to listen at least as much as you talk.
- Show genuine interest: eye contact, real questions, and your phone out of reach.
- Check your assumptions about what the other person thinks rather than guessing at their reaction.
- Ask instead of telling, and choose the right time, place, and format for harder conversations.
- Use the pause button when you're feeling rushed, impulsive, or emotional, before you respond — and close the loop on any follow-up.

One Thing I Want to Remember From This Chapter

PART III

Building the Life You Want

Track treatment thoughtfully, identify nonmedical supports, and align long-term direction with everyday practice.

ORIENT

Chapter 10: Being Your Own Scientist

If you and your doctor decide to try medication, treat it like an experiment: note your traits and their severity before starting, then track dose, effects, and side effects as you go. Use the FAST MINDS Trait Tracker (Appendix) to log this week by week.

Current Medication / Dose (if any) & what I Hope to Notice

CARRY FORWARD

Key Points: Being Your Own Scientist

A quick recap to keep this chapter oriented before you move on.

KEY POINTS

- Medication is one central tool in ADHD treatment — not the whole plan on its own.
- Walk into appointments prepared; don't assume your prescriber already has the full picture of your traits and history.
- Decide up front which traits you're hoping treatment will move, and track them as you go.
- Most side effects fade within a few days — flag anything that doesn't, quickly.
- If one medication or dose doesn't work well, that doesn't mean none will — there are multiple options worth trying.

One Thing I Want to Remember From This Chapter

CARRY FORWARD

Putting These Resources to Work

Resources work best with structure wrapped around them — accountability, rewards, a way to track progress, and reminders. Pick your top three to five priorities rather than trying to tackle everything at once.

	Area Where I Need Extra Help	Resource / Person to Assist
1		
2		
3		
4		
5		
6		
7		
8		
9		
10		
11		
12		
13		
14		
15		
16		
17		
18		
19		
20		
21		
22		
23		
24		
25		
26		
27		
28		
29		
30		
31		
32		
33		
34		
35		
36		
37		
38		
39		
40		
41		
42		
43		
44		
45		
46		
47		
48		
49		
50		
51		
52		
53		
54		
55		
56		
57		
58		
59		
60		
61		
62		
63		
64		
65		
66		
67		
68		
69		
70		
71		
72		
73		
74		
75		
76		
77		
78		
79		
80		
81		
82		
83		
84		
85		
86		
87		
88		
89		
90		
91		
92		
93		
94		
95		
96		
97		
98		
99		
100		

GOAL SETTING

Short-Term Goals (Next 1-3 Months)

Focus on high-leverage habits, immediate relief priorities, and quick executive-function wins.

GOAL SETTING

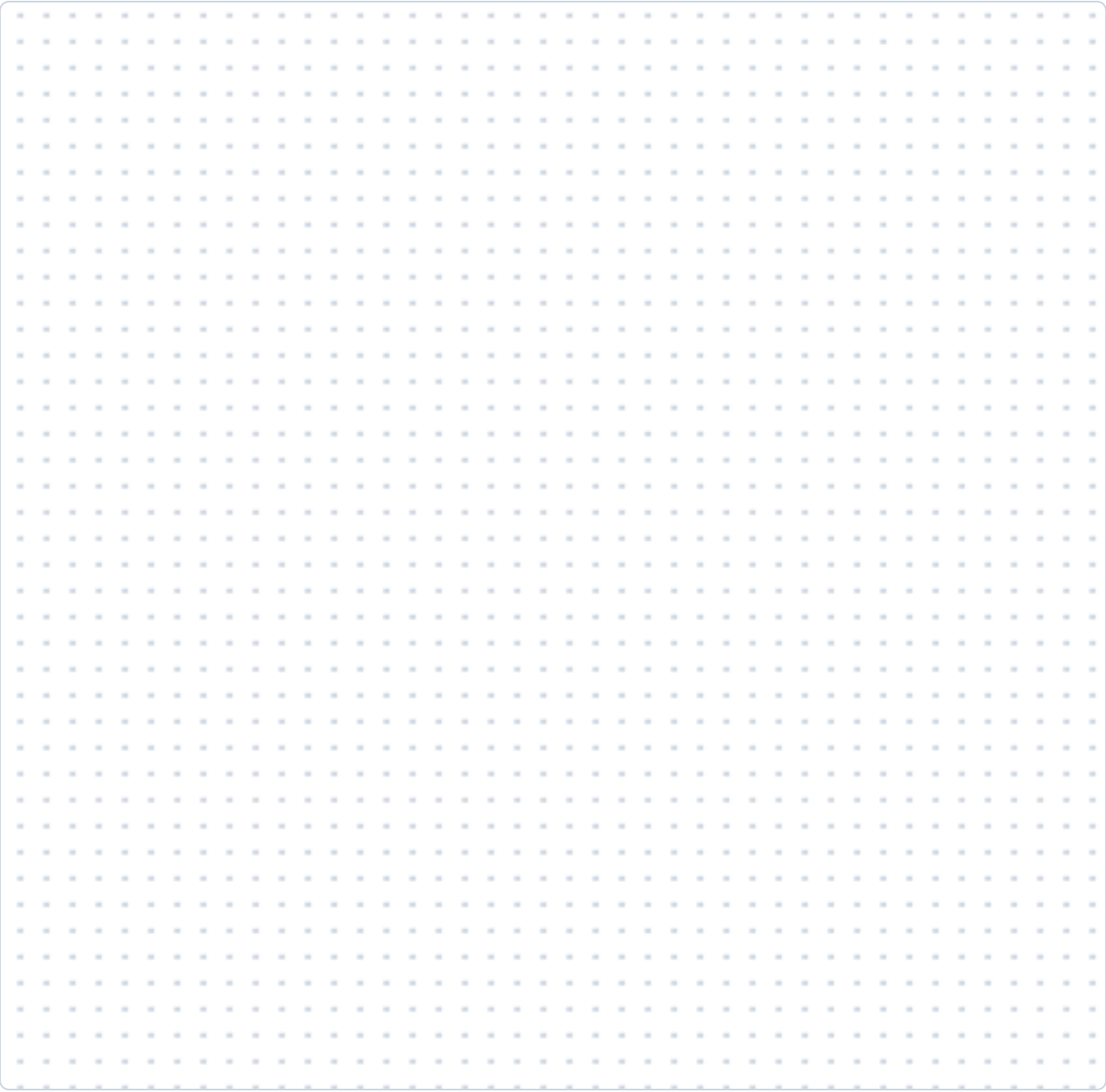
Medium-Term Goals (Next 6-12 Months)

Outline larger milestones in personal systems, relationships, and health development.

GOAL SETTING

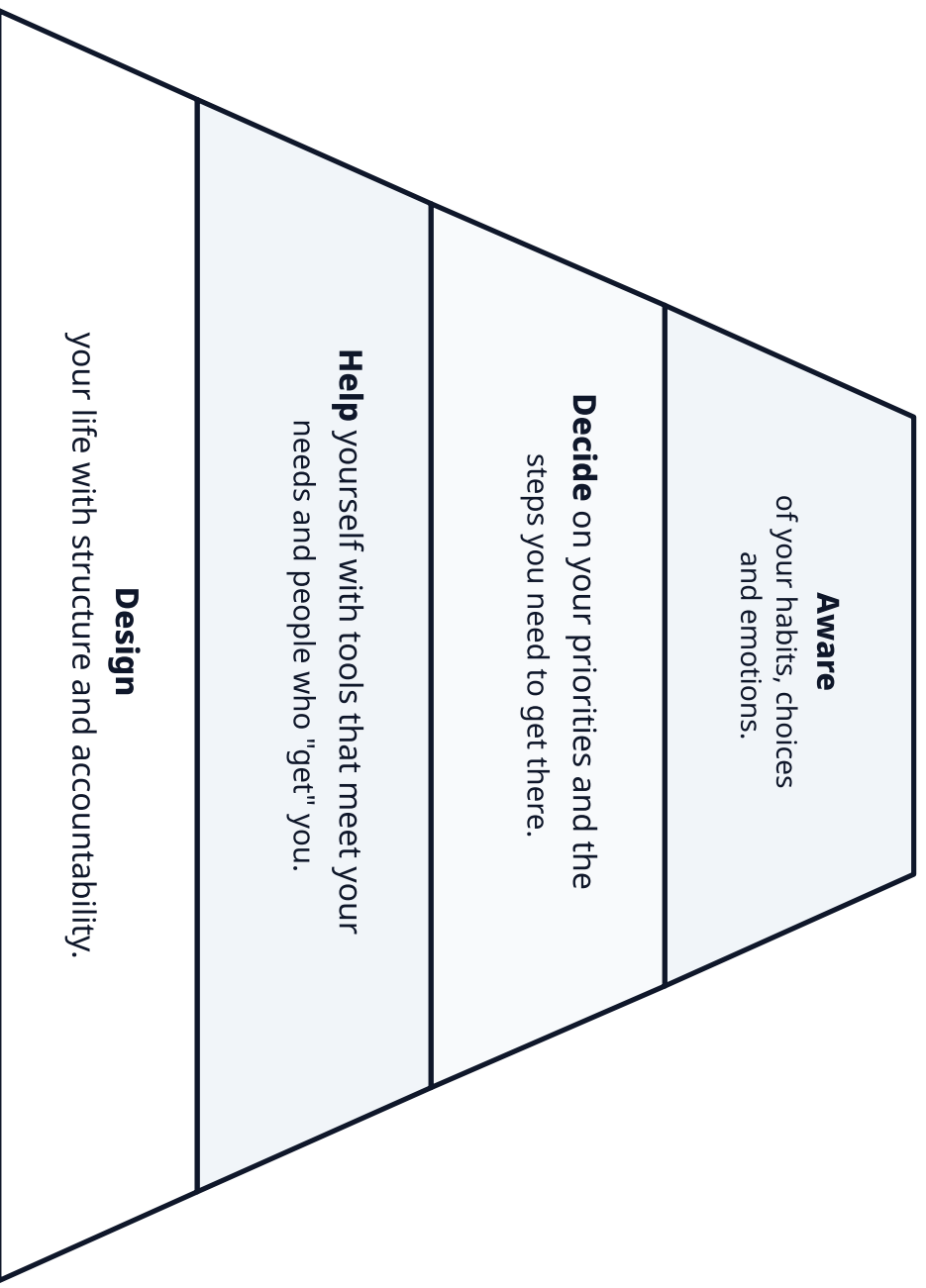
Long-Term Goals (1–5 Years)

Define your overarching vision for a thriving life aligned with your natural strengths, values, and interests.



CORE MODEL

FAST MINDS Pyramid for Success



Personal Reflection on Your Pyramid Alignment

REUSABLE FORM

Thought Record (Blank Template)

A reusable version of the Chapter 3 exercise — photocopy or redraw this page whenever a new situation calls for it.

1. Situation:

2. Context:

3. Intensity (0-10):

0
1
2
3
4
5
6
7
8
9
10

4. Thinking errors present — check any that apply and note how:

All-or-nothing thinking:

Overgeneralizing:

Discounting the positive:

Jumping to conclusions:

Magnifying or minimizing:

Catastrophizing:

Emotional reasoning:

Personalizing:

5. Rational response:

6. Re-rate the intensity, after draining out the emotion (0-10):

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	----

REUSABLE FORM

FAST MINDS Trait Tracker

Rate each trait's challenge level (1–10) before starting treatment, then log dose, week, and your new rating as you go.

FAST MINDS Trait	Before Treatment (1-10)	Dose	Week	New Rating (1-10)
Forgetful				
Achieving Below Potential				
Stuck in a Rut				
Time-Challenged				
Motivationally Challenged				
Impulsive				
Novelty Seeking				
Distractible				
Scattered				
Other Concerns				

Side Effects (what, and when they occur)

REUSABLE FORM

FAST MINDS Critical Moment Planner

Note a personal need, what days you'll act on it, and mark (*) the hours you'll take action.

[illegible]

This chart helps you plan critical moments to act on to better meet your daily needs. Consider particular moments where you can pre-empt the pitfall of a time-wasting or unhealthy activity by planning ahead.

REUSABLE FORM

Adult ADHD Self-Report Scale (Part A)

Answer the questions below rating yourself on each criterion using the scale on the right. Please answer based on how you have felt over the last 6 months.

PART A Questions	Never	Rarely	Sometimes	Often	Very Often
1. How often do you have trouble wrapping up final details once challenging parts are done?					
2. How often do you have difficulty getting things in order when performing organizational tasks?					
3. How often do you have problems remembering appointments or obligations?					
4. When you have a task that requires a lot of thought, how often do you avoid or delay starting?					
5. How often do you fidget or squirm with your hands or feet when sitting for long periods?					
6. How often do you feel overly active and compelled to do things, like driven by a motor?					

REUSABLE FORM

Adult ADHD Self-Report Scale (Part B)

PART B Questions	Never	Rarely	Sometimes	Often	Very Often
7. How often do you make careless mistakes when working on a boring or difficult project?					
8. How often do you have difficulty keeping your attention when doing boring or repetitive work?					
9. How often do you have difficulty concentrating on what people say to you, even when spoken to directly?					
10. How often do you misplace or have difficulty finding things at home or at work?					
11. How often are you distracted by activity or noise around you?					
12. How often do you leave your seat in meetings or situations where you are expected to remain seated?					
13. How often do you feel restless or fidgety?					
14. How often do you have difficulty unwinding and relaxing when you have time to yourself?					
15. How often do you find yourself talking too much in social situations?					
16. When in a conversation, how often do you finish the sentences of people before they can finish them themselves?					
17. How often do you have difficulty waiting your turn in situations when turn-taking is required?					
18. How often do you interrupt others when they are busy?					

Notes for Clinical Review